Kachwenyanja by Muzee of Kanazi

Translated and edited by P.S.

In Muzee's performance, the epic ballad of Kachwenyanja is about love, death, and the power and transcendence of poetry. Exploding outward from a loving pair -- a royal warrior and his new bride -- the constellation of themes takes shape within a particular Haya cultural world of romantic attachment, military action, and poetic genres. These cultural forms, in turn, take shape within in a Haya heroic age that was shaped by conflict between two dominant social institutions -- patrilineal clans and a centralized kingship. Depicted words and deeds arise both from universal human passions and from ethical values associated with these historical institutions, and with opposition to them.

This was the very first song Muzee chose to sing in the evening concert he gave at the large thatch-walled house (musonge) of Dionies Lutabanzibwa on August 21, 1969, in Katome village, Kihanja, in Kagera Region of Tanzania.

Plot Outline

Lines 1-6.3:
Words from the hero's poetic self-praise announce a prominent theme in the ballad.

Lines 7-15:
His two wives are introduced and their co-wifely differences described.

Notes

1-2.2, 6 -6.3: Part of the hero's *eby'ebugo*, or self-praise recitation. The bard quickly establishes the identity of the royal warrior-hero by naming his place of origin, Nsheshe, a group of islands in Lake Victoria, and by describing his physical appearance. In contrast, the identity of the clan warrior-hero in *Rukiza*, is created with kin relationships. Place of origin and individual identity were important principles in state warriorhood, as recruitment into battalions was done by locality, and rewards accrued to conspicuous individual warriors. Epic bards deftly place their heroes within classic, intentionally archaic, opposing ethical systems of the heroic age.
In the presence of royalty, a warrior would declare his identity with a spirited recitation of his self-praise or boast, *eby'ebugo.* The series of placenames in Kachwenyanja's self-praise (1-2.2) recurs throughout the epic, emphasizing the force this poetic genre exerts on the composition and theme of the epic narrative.
11 -15: Differences between the hero's cranky wives anticipates their collective contrast with the ideal dream of the feminine that is about to emerge. Thematic comparisons create rhetorical power in bardic discourse.

By the road to Nsheshe, he came from Kailongo.
In Luhunga, he came from Mugajwaale.
Luhunga, Mugajwaale,
Kakolonto and Kabwenge.
You are a child of the unbroken wilderness.

Nsheshe.
Of the white teeth,
5 *Dark gums.*

He came from Nsheshe and Kailongo.
In Luhunga he came from from Mugajwaale,
Kakolonto and Kabwenge.
You are a child of the unbroken wilderness.

My friend,
He had two wives.
One they called Ngolwa.
10 (No! they called her) Nkwanzi, Nkwanzi,
(praise of Nkwanzi not translatable.)

Then Mukabalinda was his junior wife.
Then as a woman, she put her faith in co-wife's conflict.Mukabalinda, the junior wife.

The other, then, put her faith in husband's favor.
Nkwanzi, the senior wife.
15 As the senior, she put her faith in husband's favor.

The man of Nsheshe
Slept with Mukabalinda, the junior wife.
In the early morning hours, about three,

Gwa Nsheshe akaluga Kailongo.
Luhunga akaluga Mugajwaale.
Luhunga, Mugajwaale,
Kakolonto na Kabwenge.
Oli w' ebitalaaka by' eilungu.

Nsheshe.
Eky' amaino kwela,
5 *Engino zamwilagwile.*

Akaluga Nsheshe na Kailongo.
Luhunga akaluga Mugajwaale,
Kakolonto na Kabwenge. 6.2
Oli mwaana w' ebitalaaka by' eilungu.

Baaba,
Akaba aina abakazi babili.
Omoi nibamweta Ngolwa.
10 Nkwanzi, Nkwanzi,
Nkwanzi kalukombabaile elya kikombe iwe!

Akaba aina Mukabalinda mukazi muto.
Akaba obukazi nayesiga eikaiba.
Mukabalinda muto.

Ogwo akaba nayesiga eiganzi.
Nkwanzi mukazi mukulu.
15 Obukulu bwa wenene ayesiga eiganzi.

Owa Nsheshe,
Yanyama na Mukabalinda mukazi muto.
Ekilo eitumbi lya mwenda,

Poetic Stanzas

1-6.3: *verse* in aba formed by contrast between near identical *stanzas* (a's: 1-2.2, 6-6.3) and an intervening *stanza* (b: 4-6); the identical stanzas are formed in **aa**a**b** by contrast between lines that include placenames (a's: 1, 1.1, 2, 2.1 and 6, 6.1, 6.2) and lines that include a place description (b's: 2.2 and 6.3); the intervening stanza is formed in abb by contrast between two lines composed as body part + color description (b's: 4, 5) and a single line that echoes a previous one (a: 3).

12 -15: *mirror verse* of two *stanzas* (12 -13, 14-15) each formed in **aba** by contrast between lines composed as personal name + uxoral status and lines composed as "she put her faith in" + domestic strategy; the repeating line type in the first stanza (a's: 12, 13) becomes the intervening line type in the second stanza (b: 14.1), and the intervening line type in the first stanza (b: 12.1) becomes the repeated line type in the second stanza (a's: 14, 15).

Plot Outline

Lines 16-26:
The story begins at night, as the junior wife rouses the hero from a dream. He reprimands her for denying him the vision.

Lines 27-36:
He reports that in his dream he was marrying a beautiful woman he found at the foot of a mountain. Immediately he orders his wives to prepare him for a journey. They comply truculently.

Notes

28: Crested crane, with her tufted head feathers and long, graceful neck, embodies an ideal of beauty associated with royalty, which is stereotypically tall and thin, with slow, loose-jointed, graceful movements. The crane gives her name to the hairstyle worn by brides. Her literary opposite is *akaiba*, the word for both "ring-necked dove." and "co-wife's conflict" (above 12.1). In contrast with this negative vision of clan domesticity, there is female, clan-centered Haya folktale about how the common dove bested the royal crane in knowing how to treat a husband right (Seitel 1980: 168-170).

30-36: A show of domestic resistance in the form of an over-scoured calabash and over-scented clothes gives way to the provision of at least a moderate portion of beer. Of rich symbolic importance, the giving, sharing or denying of beer defines social solidarity or marks social division. The flow of beer from to wives to husbands, from kings to warriors, from hosts to guests, between in-laws, and among other statuses in Hayaland witnesses interdependence and solidarity (Carlson 1991). A healthy flow symbolically confirms shared ethics. Beer is a metaphorical vehicle in several proverbs that comment on social division; for example, "Speaks-not-with-children brews beer by himself (i.e., without help)" and "Brewed by the tattered, drunk by the well-dressed." In epic ballads beer is also a pregnant image.

When evil roams,
When a person faints and does not revive,
When one lover meets another, 19.1
When you hear them in the royal mansion
finally disperse,

20 They lay, they embraced.
Lying there,
The man was escorted off by snoring . . .
The woman struck me with her palm!

"Woman! Is this what your father and mother taught you?"
"My lord, I didn't hit you meanly.
25 I heard something make you wimper as you slept,
My lord."

"I dreamed of marrying.
Of marrying the woman, Crested crane.
I carried her away from the foot of a mountain."

30 He said, "When morning comes, my wife,
Scour out my calabash for me."
She scoured it near to breaking.
Beer she poured injust a bit for sipping and relaxing.

I dreamed of marrying her, I did.
My clothes she smoked with incense near to burning.

35 When morning had come,
She poured in beer for sipping and relaxing.

Mbali ekibi kigendela,
Mbali omuntu akabila atahimbuuke,
Mbali omulungi abuganganilwa ondijo,
Mbali ohulila omu kikale bagwihya bwoli,

20 Lyanyaama lyafumbatana.
Kunyaama,
Omushaija yashagalwa ekigono.
Omukazi yantaho akahi.

"Mukazi! Nikwo isho na nyoko bakulagiile?"
"Waitu, tinakuteza ka bubi.
25 Nahulila wanyaama wahunizibwa,
Waitu."

"Naloota ninshwela.
Ninshwela omukazi Ntuuwa.
Namwihya omu bikiika by' eibanga."

30 Ahi, "Kabulakya mukazi wange,
Onchuundil' ekilele."
Yakichuundila okukyata.
Amaalwa yantelamu gake ag' okulangaiza.

Namuloota nimushwela 'nye.
Yazotelela okuzookya.

35 Olw' obwile bwakeile,
Yantelamu amaalwa ag' okulangaiza.

Poetic Stanzas

18-19.2: *stanza* in **aa**a**b** formed contrast between lines composed as adverbial conjunction + noun ... (a's: 18, 19, 19.1) and a line composed as adverbial conjunction + prepositional phrase (b: 19.2).

24-26: *stanza* in **aa**b**a** formed by contrast between lines with an initial term of address (a's: 24, 24.1, 26) and a line without one (b: 25).

30-36: *mirror verse* of two *stanzas* (30-32, 33-36) composed with lines comprised of adverbial clauses (30 and 35), lines of parallel syntax (31 and 34), and substanitally the same final lines (32 and 36).

A spear I took in my right hand,
A hafted knife I took in my left,
A child behind, to bear my calabash with woven cap.

40 I came to Nsheshe.
I came into Kailongo.
From Luhunga I came to Mugajwaale.
I took to the unbroken wilderness.

My beer I got out at Milama.
At Ndama, Ndama village
45 I descended to Kabilizi.
Through Migala I passed.
By the low road I ascended to Galeba's in Nyakabanga.

I came to Kahyolo village of Mpembe.
Lugasha village of Mukama.

50 I crossed Kyenguzi and Nziba streams.
At Kanyamukule village on the hill at Mazimba's, I went toward Kyabilanja.
By the low road I ascended to Muhuumuza's of He-who-Hasn't-his-Hasn't-his of Mashobe.

"Please direct me to some beer.

Hear! Spear of warriors
55 *That kills on open ground.*
He rolls them in blackened grass."

Muhuumuza said, "Because the kings lack nothing
Go by Ilogelo to the royal dwelling of Kayango,

Eichumu nata ogwa bulyo,
Omuholo nata ogwa bumosho,
Omwaana enyuma kyagil' omweeyo.

40 Naija Nsheshe.
Naija omuli Kailongo.
Luhunga naija Mugajwaale.
Nakwata omu bitalaaka by' eilungu.

Amaalwa nkagaihya Milama.
Ndama, Ndama
45 Nasooka Kabilizi.
Omuli Migala nalabamu.
Empalo nkatembela omwa Galeeba Nyakabanga.

Naija Kahyolo ka Mpembe.
Lugasha lwa Mukama.

50 Nashabuka Kyenguzi na Nziba.
Kanyamukule aha kabanga k' omwa Mazimba nakwata Kyabilanja.
Empalo nkatembela omwa Muhuumuza ya *Atainake-Tainake* ya Mashobe.

"Ondage amaalwa.

Hulila! Ichumu ly' emanzi
55 *Lwitila omu mbuga.*
Azilinga omu miyonga eikwilagula."

Muhuumuza ati, "Olw' abakama batabulilwa,
Olabe Ilogelo omwa Kayango,

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 37-52:
Properly equipped, the hero sets out, travels along and approaches the king's palace

Lines 53-71:
He inquires about beer and is directed insice, where he greets the king and receives a full measure of beer.

NOTES

52: He-who-hasn't-his: this personal name echoes a common proverb, *atainake tazinduka,* "He-who hasn't his doesn't-travel," which can be used to curtly refuse a request.

54-56: This second part of the hero's self-praise recurs several times. Blackened grass can be found between villages on fallow land burnt annually to keep it clear of unwanted fauna and flora. The understood direct object of the verb "rolls" is enemy corpses.

57.1: Kayango represents an archaic, indigenous kingship. The name derives from the Bayango, a pre-Hinda dynasty in Ihangilo kingdom, where the epic is set (Cory n.d. :35).

POETIC STANZAS

37-39: *stanza* in **aab** formed by contrast between lines composed as direct object + "I took" + left or right (a's: 37, 38) and a line that begins with a subject (b: 39).
40-43: *stanza* in **aa**a**b** formed by contrast between lines composed as [place name] + "I came" + placename (a's: 40, 41, 42) and a single line composed as "I took" + place description (b: 43).

45-52: *verse* in **aba** of *mirror stanzas* (a's: 45-47 and 50-52) composed of lines with parllel syntax (45 and 50 : verb initial; 46 and 51: verb final, or almost final) and with the same initial words (47 and 52 "By the low road I ascended to ..."); a pair of lines (b: 48, 49) intervenes between the stanzas to create the aba pattern.

Plot Outline

Lines 53-71 (cont.):
He inquires about beer and is directed insice, where he greets the king and receives a full measure of beer.

Notes

58: Dispute-ender is the name given to the third child, if male, born after twins.

62: Literally, "hawks died-without-male-issue, breasts, of (a possessive refering to hawks) Hayaland." Hawks may refer to royalty, as they do for the non-Hinda Bankango rulers of Kyamutwala kingdom, whose *mulumuna,* or totemic "clan brother," is the hawk. Hawks are distinguished from non-carnivorous birds by their diet, the same manner in which rulers and their affiliated clans were distinguished from commoners. Childlessness may signify that Kayango's dynasty did not reproduce itself, but was succeeded by the Hinda. Kaijaige (19) relates a similar story about the way the rule passed from an indigenous clan to the invading Hinda in Kymutwala kingdom. The feminine image of breasts may refer to the inferior status of the indigenous clan under Hinda rule.

71: This episode, completed with a generous pouring of beer, introduces the royal institutional setting of the narrative. The warrior is a well-spoken, well-regarded supporter of an authentic king.

71-75.1: These anachronisms-Kamachumu is now a relatively large town; George is a Christian name-assist the audience in following the route taken by the traveller.

Kayango of Dispute-ender,
Dispute-ender of By'olugano,
60 *By'olugano of Nyabwilu,*
Nyabwilu of Kahange,
Childless Hawks of Hayaland."

I took the road directly.
    I came to Nyamukazi.
In Lwakayanja on the hill
    At Kamuhabwa's,
    I came to Kazilango.
65 At Kayango's royal mansion I arrived.

I go and find he's in, the scion of By'olugano.
"My lord, Long life to the Fearless one, Father of men!"

Ahihyaya!
"Long life to the Fearless one, Father of men!
    I salute you with a greeting of love and fear.
    I add one to buy life.
70 Provider, I have a great thirst."
He poured it 'til it filled.

I was swallowed by the road to Enjelu.
I turned at the house of Bilaze of George.

In Kamachumu village at Milama
75 –It hadn't yet become a town–
    I went toward the spring at Kamilabala.

At Bukende's at the forecourt,
I went toward Nyazilo.

Kayango ka Kamala-mpaka,
Kamala-mpaka ka By'olugano,
60 *By'olugano bya Nyabwilu,*
Bwilu bwa Kahange,
Empungu echwekile amabele za Buhaya."

Nakwata gumoi.
    Naija Nyamukazi.
Omuli Lwakayanja akashozi,
    Omwa Kamuhaabwa,
    Naija Kazilango.
65 Omwa Kayango nagobamu.

Ngya nshanga alimu ka Byolugano.
"Waitu, Enshongole malama, Ishe abashaija!"

Ahihyaya!
"Enshongole malama, Ishe abashaija!
    Nalamya eky' engonzi n' obutini.
    Natekaho eky' obwegula-mwoyo.
70 Lugaba, nyina eliho lingi."
Yantelamu kyaijula.

Namilwa ogwa Enjelu.
Nayekuba omwa Bilaze owa Jooje.

Kamachumu Milama
75 - Ekaba etakabaile mugini.-
    Nakwata akachulo ka Kamilabala.

Omwa Bukende omu ilembo,
Nakwata Nyazilo.

Poetic Stanzas

58-62: *stanza* in **aa**aa**b** formed by contrast between lines of praise-names that cohere by linking the last word of one line repeated as first word of next (a's: 58, 59, 60, 61) and a final line of praisenames not so linked (b: 62).

69-71: *stanza* in **aa**aa**b** formed by contrast between lines comprised of the quoted speech of the warrior (a's: 69, 69.1, 69.2, 70) and a line comprised of the narrated response of the king (b: 71).

76-77.2: *stanza* in **abab** formed by contrast betweeen lines composed as zero verb + preposition + placename (a's: 76, 77.1) and lines composed as verb initial + placename (b's: 77, 77.2).

Plot Outline

Lines 72-81:
He resumes his journey, and eventually reaches the foot of a mountain, where he meets two noblewomen gathering straw.

Lines 82-95:
The three greet, and the hero immediately proposes to them both; the one named Nyakaandalo refuses, citing the custom that forbids marrying two women in a single day.

Lines 96-104.2:
The hero chooses Nyakaandalo, but before she will answer, she asks him to identify himself; he does so by reciting his self-praise poetry and she accepts.

Notes

82-87: These salutations communicate status. In general, greetings refer to and confirm aspects of social relationships. Being first to greet is a way of conferring status on the addressee. The warrior's opening statement of observation (82) is not a greeting but is the kind of utterance sometimes used to induce an addressee to greet first - and thus admit lower status. But when the women "agree" to greet (83), by straightening up from their back-bending work and even providing the warrior a clean place to sit, he greets first (86), giving the women almost the same greeting he gave to the king himself (67).
92: Nyakandaalo's assertion about this somewhat obscure rule governing the marriage of sisters is correct. She shows herself an expert in clan affairs but outside them, since she can be married without negotiations or payment of bridewealth. Her mastery of clan affairs is repeatedly demonstrated over the course of the narrative.

98.1, 98.2: Hinda and Munkango are the ruling clans in their respective kingdoms, Kihanja and Kyamtwala.. The latter's royal dwelling is in Kabale. She praises the warrior's regal appearance.

In Kakila at Njwanga's,
I descended Nyamilyango mountain.

I met girls there
I meet two noblewomen.
80 They were gathering straw
They are there, at the foot of a mountain.

"Straw gathering's work, my mothers!"
They straightened up;they agreed.
A sheaf of straw they placed for me or . . .
85 I obliged; I sat upon it.
"Long life to the Fearless one!"
They said, "I greet you, my lord, Wealth-of-the-People."

"You two women,
Consent and I will marry you."
90 She refused, Nyakaandalo.
She said, "My lord, it is forbidden.
Two women are not married beneath one sun.

Marry my sister,
And I will come behind to bear a wedding gift.
Or marry me,
95 And my sister will bear the gift."

"I shall marry you, Nyakaandalo!"
"You man who'd marry me, who are you?
Before you I'm amazed.
In Kihanja if you are not a Hinda, my kings,
You are honored in Kabale as a Munkango."

Kakila omwa Njwanga,
Nasooka Nyamilyango.

Nkashangaho abaisiki -
Nshangaho enyaluka ibili.
80 Bakaba mbaihya obunyasi -
Bali omu bikiika by' eibanga.

"Mwagila bwihi bamaawe!"
Bainuguka baikiliza.
Omuganda gw' obunyasi baguntelaho bwangili...
85 Nakunda nagwikalila.
"Enshongole malama!"
Bati, "Nkushula waitu *Byabantu*."

"Inywe bakazi inywembili,
Mukunde, nabashwela."
90 Yayanga Nyakandaalo.
Ahi, "Waitu nikizila.
Abakazi babili tibashwelwa izooba limo.

Oshwele mulumuna wange,
Inye ndaluga enyuma nkuzilimile.
Angili oshwele 'nye,
95 Mulumuna wange alakuzilimila."

"Nakushwela Nyakandaalo!"
"Iwe mushaija yanshwela, oli muki?
Omu maisho gawe wanshobeza.
Kihanja kolaba otali Muhinda, bakama bange,
Nokunilwa Kabale oli Munkango."

Poetic Stanzas

78-81: *stanza* formed in three overlapping structures: in **abab** by contrast between lines whose initial verb is in the distant past (a's: 78, 80) and lines whose initial verb is in the narrative present (b's: 78, 81); in aabb by contrast between lines in which the verbs are in the first person (a's: 78, 79) and lines in which the verbs are in the third person (b's: 80, 81); in **aa**ab by contrast between lines composed as transitive verb phrase + direct object (a's: 78, 79, 80) and a single line composed as verb "to be" + prepositional phrase (b: 81); the last reading foregrounds the uniqueness of the final line, which thematically fulfills a dream promise (29).
82-87: *compound stanza* of three couplets, each comprising an action-reaction sequence, formed in **aab** by contrast between couplets that depict pre-greeting exchanges and are marked by double verb constructions in their second lines (a's: 82-83, 84-85), and a final couplet that quotes the exchange of greetings (b: 86-87).

88-92: *compound stanza*, 2 + 2 + 1, formed in **aab** by semantic contrast between line pairs that request and refuse (a's: 88-89, 90-91) and a single line that explains (b: 92).

92.1-95: *stanza* in **abab** formed contrast between lines composed as "marry" + direct object (a's: 92.1, 94) and lines composed as "...bring a gift" (b's: 93, 95).

Plot Outline

Lines 105-118: The Call
After only six days of married life, the royal drums summon the warrior to battle; the hero must go.

Notes

99-104.2: Praise becomes more and more central to the plot and character motivations. Here it wins Nyakandaalo's admiration and consent. The two recurring parts of Kachwenyanja's praise appear together, joined by another detail about his distinctive appearance. The warrior's hairyness is a conventional sign of strength and easily aroused anger.
107: As the phrase, "on the fifth..." suggests, a divorced woman is secluded only four days.

108-150: In this episode the warrior receives a call to uphold the ethics of his social standing by acting with its virtues. He must choose between his king and his dream-sent wife. This Call episode provides a thematic paradigm that structures most of the action depicted in this epic. Ethical knowledge associated with particular institutions motivates and is articulated by events. The warrior's self-knowledge makes his body an instrument of the state as it reverberates with the king's drummed summons (117.1).

Poetic Stanzas

99-101.2: *compound stanza*, 2 + 2 + 1, formed in **aab** by couplets (a's: 99-100, 101-101.1) whose lines cohere internally by parallel composition as "mother, our home is in" + placename, and as "I come from" + placename + "and" + placename, respectively, contrasted with a final line that has a distinct composition (b: 101.2).

"Mother, our home is in Nsheshe.
100 *Mother, our home is in Kailongo.*
I come from Luhunga and Mugajwaale.
I come from Kakolonto and Kabwenge.
I am a child of unbroken wilderness.

My hair dulls any razor.

Hear! Spear of warriors
Hear! Spear of warriors
That kills on open ground."
She said, "Father, you have married me,
Wealth-of-the-people."

105 I obliged, I married her.
I secluded her four days.
On the fifth the already married one emerged.
On the sixth I had embraced her . . .

I hear drums that stand at Nsheshe.
I hear those that stand at Kailongo.
110 I hear those of Luhunga.
I hear those of Mugajwaale.
I hear those of Kakoronto and Kabwenge.
I hear those that stand in unbroken wilderness.

I had embraced her lying on my back.
She said, "My husband, what is it?"
115 "I hear drums speak.
Those that stand at Nsheshe,
Those that roar,
They roar within me."

"Maawe, omwaitu ni Nsheshe.
100 *Maawe, omwaitu ni Kailongo.*
Nkaluga Luhunga na Mugajwaale.
Nkaluga Kakolonto na Kabwenge.
Ndi mwaana w' ebitalaaka by' eilungu.

Eishoke ikimbisize olwejo.

Hulila! Ichumu ly' emanzi
Hulila! Ichumu ly' emanzi 104
Lwitil' omu mbuga"
Ahi, "Tata wanshwela *Byabantu*."

105 Nkakunda namushwela.
Namwalika ebilo binai.
Ekya katanu enyailiya yayaluka.
Ekya mukaga nkaba mufumbasile...

Mpulil' engom' ezayema Nsheshe.
Mpulil' ezayema Kailongo.
110 Mpulil' eza Luhunga.
Mpulil' eza Mugajwaale.
Mpulil' eza Kakolonto na Kabwenge.
Mpulil' ezayema omu bitalaaka by' eilungu.

Nkaba mufumbasile, nagalama.
Ahi, "Mushaija wange wabaki?"
115 "Nahulila engoma zagamba:
Ezayema Nsheshe,
Ezajuga,
Zanjuga omu nda."

108-113: *stanza* formed alternately in **aa**aaa**b** by contrast between lines that end with a placename (a's:108-112) and a single line that ends with a place description (b: 113) and in **aab**bb**a** by contrast between lines that contain a relative verb (a's: 108, 109, 113) and lines that substitute a possessive particle for it (b's: 110, 111, 112).

114.1-118: *compound stanza* in aba formed by contrast between couplets composed of independent clauses (a's: 114.1-115, 117.1-118) and a couplet of relative verbs (b: 116-117); the passage can also be seen as an annular structure abccba: locutive + quoted speech (114.1)/ [drum] + verb (115)/ relative verb (116)/relative verb (117)/ [drum] + verb (117.1)/ locutive + quoted speech (118).

Plot Outline

Lines 119-36.1:
He orders her to prepare provisions for his journey, but all signs foretell disaster; he believes she is trying to prevent his going.

Notes

Nyakandaalo uses wifely knowledge to try to keep him home, he suspects (136.1). The status of the couple's union outside clan is underlined by Nyakandaalo's lack of "storage sack and seeds" (121), which accompany a clan-sanctioned bride to her new home. It is also underlined by their symmetrical address of one another, "dear one" answered by "yes, dear one" (146). These constitute the thematic building blocks of the epic:

- two kinds of knowledge: that of the self (*okw'-emanya*), which binds one to the ethics of a role (the warrior's intuition of his duty); and that of the other (*oku-manya*), which empowers one to understand and/or manipulate (Nyakandaalo's augury/ artifice);
- institutional bases for knowledge: state (the king's summons), clan (by negative implication), and a romantic place outside of clan (marked by symmetrical address);
- richly symbolic speech: symmetrical endearments and poetic praise;
- richly symbolic codes: the royal drums;
- bodies inscribed with institutional meanings: the warrior's resonant response.

These thematic dimensions underlie most episodes, creating coherent and recurring patterns of significance in the work as a whole.

He said, "I must go to war.

My wife, make up provisions."
120 "Provisions of what sort?
I did not come in marriage with a storage sack and seeds."

"Please go and grind some millet."
She said, "My lord, the grinding stone has dropped into it."
"Go dig my large white yam for me."
125 "The leafy stems outside are eaten by bugs.
I found the root inside blocked off by solid rock."
"Go dig for me *enkongo* yams."
"My lord, I've cut and piled only rotten chunks."
"Hand me my bow."
"Provider, its string's been cut by rats."
130 "Hand it to me. I'll use banana bast.
Hand me my spear."
She said, "Its shaft's been eaten away."
"Please hand me, Provider . . .
Hand me that calabash of mine."
135 "My lord, it's been taken over by a spider.

Don't go! All, all signs foretell unnatural wonders."
"You, wife–you show experience in marriage."

He of Nsheshe and Kailongo,
In Luhunga he comes from Mugajwaale,
In Kakolonto he comes from Kabwenge.
Child of unbroken wilderness.

140 He said, "Hand me . ..
I heard him break off a piece of cooked porridge and chew it.

Poetic Stanzas

119-136.1: *compound stanza* in **aa**aaaaa**b** formed by contrast between conversational exchanges begun by the warrior (a's: 119-121, 122-123, 124-125.1, 126-127, 128-130, 131-132, 133-135) and a single exchange begun by his wife (b: 136-136.1).

Ahi, "Natabaalakwo.

Mukazi wange, onkol' entanda."
120 "Entanda nkol' eya?
Tinashweilwe kitende na mpambo."

"Ogende ose obulo."
Ahi, "Waitu bwalagalwamu enseiso."
"Ogye onyihile ekilai kyange."
125 "Eky' olugulu kyamalwa entole.
Nashanga eky' okuzimu olwazi lwabamba."
"Ogende ogye onyihile ekongo."
"Waitu ebigenge natuma."
"Mpeleza obutai bwange"
"Lugaba obugunga bwatemwa empanami."
130 "Obwo ompeleze nteho ekyai."
"Mpeleza eichumu."
Ati, "Olubango lwabungwa."
"Ompeleze Lugaba...
Mpeleza ekilele kyange ekyo."
135 "Waitu kyakwatwamu olububi.

Oyoshe! Byona byona byashula amahano."
"Iwe mukazi, wantekaho ak' enyailiya."

Owa Nsheshe Kailongo,
Luhunga aluga Mugajwaale,
Kakolonto aluga Kabwenge.
Mwaana w' ebitalaaka by' eilungu.

140 Ati, "Ompeleze...
Nkahulila ekishuniko yaihyaho yakikanjula.

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 140-150:
He outfits himself and departs, first reciting poetry he calls "self-praise" but is actually praise for their love and a description of an omen that may foretell his death.

Lines 151-158:
In the fields near Lugongo village, Kachwenyanja comes upon the enemy. One of their number who wanted to form a blood brotherhood with the hero greets peacefully, but the hero throws the words back as a taunt, provoking combat.

NOTES

141.2: Banana bast makes a poor bowstring, and its use seems to express the warrior's determination to answer the call at any cost, even if he must go poorly equipped. The same banana bast on Littleman's bow (166.6) is a sign of low status.

148: A small leaf seems to be an omen of death, but the following line shows the warrior thinks only of triumph.

149: A first strike occurs when a hunting party kills a large animal. Two hunters are rewarded with special portions: the one who strikes first and the one whose thrust follows his and makes the kill certain. The warrior's self-praise recitation creates poetic associations between hunting, war, praise, and reward that will reverberate throughout the epic.

155.1-157: In this interchange, the first and last quoted lines (155.1, 157) are spoken by the enemy warrior, the middle two (156 - 156.1) by the hero. Kachwenyanja rejects the desired blood-brotherhood (155), a kin-based bond so markedly respected by the clan hero in *Rukiza (96-98.1)*. Kachwenyanja receives the very same deference in greeting he bestowed upon his bride-to-be (86) and his king (67), but he twists the salutation to an insult and hurls it back. Unlike his enemy, the hero has cast aside all kin -like caring on the battlefield.

POETIC STANZAS

144-146.1: *stanza* in **a**a**ba** formed by contrast between lines with positive verbs in an unmarked word order (a's: 144, 145, 146.1) and a line with a negative verb preceded by its direct object (b: 146).

155.1 -157: *stanza* in **ab**b**a** formed by contrast between friendly greetings (a's: 155.1, 157) and antagonistic replies (b's: 156, 156.1).

She handed him his bow. He strung it with
banana bast.

When he left the forecourt,
"My wife, I would recite my praise to you:

For I married you but a few days ago,
145 *And I have love for you and long to see your face.*
Your name I have not yet pronounced.
You call me, 'Dear one'; I answer, 'Yes, dear one.'

When in your strength you cultivate,
If a small leaf should fall before you,
Say this: 'If he did not make the first strike,
surely he made the kill.'

150 *I go to war, the Buffalo."*

When he reached Lugongo field,
He took the road to Lutenge in Kashalala.
In Lugongo he finds all the warriors.
Their shields, my lord, they'd walled together.
He obliged. He taunted one out.

155 The man there wanted blood brotherhood with him.
He said, "Long life to the Fearless one!"
He said, "You've already fallen, 'Long life to the Fearless one!'"
He said, "The sun arose on your misfortune!"
He said, "In peace, I awoke in peace."
He taunted one out, the Buffalo.

He killed, he boasted of him.

Yamuheleza obuta. Yataho akai.

Kanatulukile omu ilembo,
"Mukaziwa nkwebugile:

Manti nkushweile juba 'nye,
145 *Maha nyina engonzi n' olushusho.*
Eibala lyawe tinkalyatwile
Nonyeta, 'Baaba,' ninkweta 'Baaba inya.'

Agoliba nolima,
Akababi kakakugwa omu maishonu,
Ohi, 'Kalaba ataita yashonga.'

150 *Natabaala Mbogo."*

Kayagobile omu Lugongo,
Yakwata Kashalala Lutenge.
Omu Lugongo ashanga emanzi zona.
Engabo, *waitu*, ikaba ikwataine.
Yakunda yaishomoza.

155 Akab' aliho omushaija ndigonza kunywaana.
Ati, "Enshongole malama!"
Ahi, "Wagwa, 'Enshongole malama!'"
Ahi, "Bwanyu bwakya bwolo!"
Ahi, "Milembe, naimuka eli milembe."
Yaishomoza *Mbogo*.

Yamwita yamwegamba.

Plot Outline

Lines 159-164:
He kills four enemy warriors, proudly boasting and then sitting on the last in an act of self-display.

Lines 164.1-173:
A poorly dressed and equipped man appears on the enemy side and warns the hero to flee his bow, but the hero refuses.

Notes

162: The warrior sits upon an enemy corpse as one would a stool in an act of personal display, thus beginning a series of meaningful exchanges wrought with human bodies, like the mutilations in *Rukiza (126, 132.1)*.

164.1-166.1: "Little man," *aka-shaija,* is derived from *omu-shaija,* "man," as *aka-mwana,* "cute little child" is derived from *o(mu)-mwana,* "child."

170-171: "Flee my bow... sire a misfortune" are weak words, like those of the would-be blood-brother (155.1). They thematize clan values of caring and reproduction, weak responses his clansmen's deaths, which call for vengeance.

Poetic Stanzas

159-162: *stanza* in **aa**a**b** formed by contrast between lines that end in "boasted of him" (a's: 159, 160, 161) and one line that ends in "sat down upon him" (b: 162).

163 -164: *stanza* in **ab**b**a** formed by contrast between lines whose verb is "to get up" (a's: 163, 164) and lines whose verb is "he used" (b's: 163.1-163.2).

164.1-166.1: *stanza* in **aa**b**a** formed by contrast between between lines whose verbs have the same subject (a's: 164.1, 165, 166.1) and a line that has no verb (b: 166).

160 The second, he boasted of him.
The third, he boasted of him.
The fourth, he sat down upon.

When he stood up,
He used his tobacco.
He used his packet of coffee berries.
He stood up to fight, *the Buffalo* .

At that place, there was a little man.
165 The little man had tied a cloak of barkcloth on.
His bow, a *Hits-not-cattle* plant,
And he'd strung it with banana bast.

He obliged and called out to him.
"You man, the light-skinned one, you!
In Kihanja if you are not a Hinda,
You'll be honored in Kabale as a Munkango.

170 Flee my bow.
Let me not sire misfortune for you.
Let me not sire misfortune for you."

He refused, *the Spear of warriors*.

He's gone, he's let one fly.
175 He's pierced his breast.
The warrior he was, Kachwenyanja,
He plucked it out; he sucked the wound!
He said, "Hindas, I've been bitten by a dog.
Just let me go and cut the little man in two."

160 Owa kabili yamwegamba.
Owa kashatu yamwegamba.
Owa kana yamushuntamila bwoli.

Kayaimukile,
Yatamu etaaba.
Yatamu yakola omutana gw' emwani.
Yaimuka kulwana *Mbogo*.

Akaba alimu akashaija.
165 Akashaija kashumikize olubugu.
Obuta bwa wenene kitatelante,
Manti kabuleegize ekyai.

Kakunda kamweta.
"Iwe mushaija alikwela iwe!
Kihanja kolaba otali Muhinda,
Olakunilwa Kabale oli Munkango.

170 Olandugila omu buta.
Oleke ntakuzaalila amahano.
Oleke ntakuzaalila amahano."

Yayanga *Ichumu ly' emanzi*.

Kagya kaguhongolola.
175 Kamuchumita omu ibele.
Akaba ali manzi Kachwenyanja.
Yagunyukula yagwenyunya!
Ahi, "Bahinda nalibw' embwa.
Muleke ngye nteme akashaija."

168-172: two *stanzas* in **abb** formed, respectively, by contrast between lines composed as placename + verb "to be" + clan name (b's: 169, 169.1) and a line of address that begins and ends with "you" (a: 168), and by contrast between duplicate lines with initial subjunctive verbs (b's: 171, 172) and a single line with an initial future indicative verb that has subjunctive force (a: 170).

144-173: *verse passage* of four sets of line groups. Each set is finalized by a formulaic line composed as initial verb + praise name; the sets are patterned as **aa**a**b:** three sets, each one comprised of two line groups + a formulaic line in which the praise-name is "buffalo" (a's: 144-146.1 + 147-149 + 150; 151-154 + 155-157 + 158; 159 -162 + 163 -163.1 + 164) are finalized by a single set comprised of three line groups + single line formula in which the praisename is "spear of warriors" (b: 164.1-166.1 + 167-169.1 + 170-172 + 173). Seven of these ten line groups are composed as stanzas.

174-176.1: *stanza* in **aa**b**a** formed by contrast between lines whose verbs initiate or continue double verb patterns in the near past tense (a's: 174, 175, 176.1) and one line whose initial verb is inflected in the distant past tense (b: 176).

When Kachwenyanja tried to cut the little man,
180 The little one cut his throat. It spilled out on the ground.
He killed him on white earth.
He rolled him in blackened grass.
He killed him on white earth.
He rolled him in blackened grass.
The Muhamba cut his right hand off.
I saw that deed the Muganguzi warriors do.
185 Weyeyeyeye

In that place he'd left behind
His wife has a maidservant.
His wife has I-laugh-knowingly.
I answer, "Mother, knowledge is within."

She said, "Go and receive my husband.
He's gone to Lugongo."

She pressed out sweet banana mash.
She brought fire for his pipe.
190 A packet of coffee berries . . .

When Nyakaandalo came to Lugongo,
She met Kabwengo.
"My lord, you've travelled far!"
She said, "My lord, you've travelled far!
195 Direct me to my husband."
"My lady, he's there in the rear, herding the plunder.
Be assured: If he did not make the first strike,
surely he made the kill."

She went further and met Nkunzile.

Kayagile kutema akashaija Kachwenyanja,
180 Katema ebikya. Byalagala.
Kamwitila omu bilikwela.
Kamuzilinga omu miyonga eikwilagula.
Kamwitila omu bilikwela.
Kamuzilinga omu miyonga ekwilagula.
Omuhamba katema ogwa bulyo.
Nkabon' ez' omuganguzi akola.
185 Weyeyeyeye

Mbali yalugile enyuma
Omukazi ain' omwaana.
Mukaziwe aina *Nshekel' okumanya*
Nti, "Maawe *obumanyi bukuli omu nda*."

Ahi, "Chwekela omushaija wange.
Agenzile Lugongo."

Yajunga omulamba.
Yataho omulilo.
190 Omutaana gw' emwani...

Kayaizile omu Lugongo,
Abuganganwa Kabwengo.
"Waitu waiyukayo!"
Ahi, "Waitu waiyukayo!
195 Ndaga omushaija wange."
"Waitu ali enyuma oku nafunya eminyago.
Lwona kalaba ataita, alaba yashonga."

Agya abuganganwa Nkunzile.

Plot Outline

Lines 174-184.1:
Struck by the man's arrow, a weakened Kachwenyanja still boasts victory, but is cut down and mutilated by the enemy.

Lines 186-190:
At home the wife and her maidservant prepare for his return.

Lines 191-99.1:
Going out to receive him, the wife asks about her husband from several warriors returning from the battle, but is not told the truth.

Notes

181-2: The sequence of white and black thematizes the hero's dishonor. The lines echo his boast (55-56), but their sense has been reversed: what he said he would do to another has been done to him, just as his more recent boast was reversed (177-180).

184: The taking of the "right hand" as trophy later turns out to have been his penis, a mutilation that answers the hero's use of enemy dead for self-display. The clansman's act inscribes (reproductive) weakness on the warrior's body.

184, 184.1: A Muhamba is a native of Kihanja kingdom. Buganguzi is a village in Ihangilo kingdom renown for the fierceness of its fighters.

187: The bard says "child," but the maidservant referred to is a *muzana,* a female domestic slave or courtesan. One could become a *muzana* when her father died without male issue or sent her to the king as payment for a fine, for an allotment of land, or for food in time of famine. Although of low social status, courtesans were famous for their mastery of verbal art and other stylized practices of the palace. A king might bestow a courtesan on a follower as a wife or a domestic servant in reward for service. A *muzana* was summoned and had to answer according to the whim of her superior; the exchange might allude to a memorable situation at the court or at home. The bard assumes the *muzana*'s point of view, answering in the first person (188.1), perhaps assuming the mantle of her verbal artistry.
189.2-190: Banana mash, fire, and coffee berries are signs of knowing domesticity.

196: The plunder of war refers to cattle. 200: This saying signifies by contrast that close kin will not tell the truth, being afraid to bring disorder. Only a stranger will dare.

Poetic Stanzas

179-184.1: *compound stanza* of four line pairs, formed in **abba** by conrast between pairs that repeat the word "cut" (a's: 179-180, 184-184.1; the latter pair includes an aside) and repeated pairs whose constituent lines are composed as verb + preposition + color term (b's: 181-182, 183-183.1).

186-188.1: *stanza* in **aaab** formed by contrast between narration (a's: 186-188) and quoted discourse (b: 188.1).
189.2-190: *stanza* in **aab** by contrast between lines composed as initial verb + noun (direct object) (a's: 189.2, 189.3) and a line composed as zero verb + noun (b: 190).

191 -209.1: *verse passage* in **aab** formed by contrast between two similar linegroups (a's: 191-196.1, 197-199.1) and one that begins similarly but diverges(b: 200-209.1).

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 200-217:
Finally, a warrior from another kingdom, who discerns the hero's identity through the wife's quoting of his self-praise, reveals the fact of the hero's death.

NOTES

201: A Muziba is a native of a northern kingdom of Hayaland..

219: Nyakandaalo wailed only once, but a traditional wife would have wailed many more times. Lamentations announce a death to a village and mark the arrival of each relative to the house of mourning. The heroine acts outside of clan practice.

POETIC STANZAS

210-217: *verse passage* in abac formed by contrast between repeated couplets (a's: 210-211.1, 214-215) and linegroups that advance the narrative (b and c: 212-213, 216-217)

.

She said, "Father, you've travelled far!
Direct me to my husband, *the Buffalo* ."
He said, "He's in the rear herding plunder of war."
He said, "If he did not make the first strike,
surely he made the kill."

200 Bad news is brought by a traveller.
She went further and met a Muziba.
They'd fled. He'd fallen behind.
He wiped sweat from his face.
"You, man, you've travelled far!"
She said, "You've travelled far, Provider!
205 Direct me to my husband."

He said, "What does your husband look like?"
"He has sideburns and a beard.

He of Nsheshe came from Kailongo,
In Luhunga he came from Mugajwaale,
He of Kakolonto and Kabwenge.
A child of the unbroken wilderness."
[Stop to change recording tape]

210 He said, "They have killed your husband!
They killed him on white earth.
They rolled him in blackened grass.
They have killed him. They have killed him.
He was killed by a little man whose cloak was barkcloth.

He killed him on white earth.
215 He rolled him in blackened grass.
The Muhamba cut his right hand off.
I saw that deed the Muganguzi warriors do.
When it did not oblige he took his penis for a trophy."

She said, "What shall I do?"
She wailed but once.
220 The people of Lutenge up above could not hear her.

Ahi, "Tata waihyukayo!
Ndaga omushaijawa *Mbogo*."
Ati, "Ali enyuma nafunya eminyago."
Ahi, "Kalaba ataita, alaba yashonga."

200 Nkulu mbi etwalwa mugenzi.
Agya abuganganwa Omuziba.
Bailukile bamusigile ali enyuma.
Nashaimula empita.
"Iwe mushaja waihyukayo!"
Ahi, "Waiyukayo lugaba!
205 Ndaga omushaija wange."

Ati, "Omushaija nashana ata?"
"Aina amatalila aina n' empembwe.

Owa Nsheshe akaluga Kailongo,
Luhunga akaluga Mugajwaale,
Owa Kakolonto na Kabwenge.
Omwaana w' ebitalaaka by' eilungu."
[Stop to change recording tape]

210 Ati, "Omushaija bamwita!
Bamwitila omu bilikwela.
Bamuzilinga omu miyonga elikwilagula.
Bamwita, bamwita.
Yaitwa akashaija kashumikile olubugu.

Kamwitila omu bilikwela.
215 Kamuzilinga omu miyonga elikwilagula.
Omuhamba katema ogwa bulyo.
Nabon' ez' Omuganguzi akola.
Kayayanga kamwihyaho enshembe."

Ahi, "Ngile ntai?"
Endulu yatamu emoi.
220 Aba Lutenge olugulu tibahulila.

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 218-231:
Nyakandaalo laments.

Lines 231.1-240: The Call ii
With her maidservant, she plans revenge. :

NOTES

224: They 'do' themselves with herbs, that is, women use sweet smelling herbs in preparation for lovemaking.

226-227.1: She invokes the praise of the hero (54-56), reclaiming it from its reversal in the episode of his death and restoring it as a poetic evocation of his warrior ethic.

232-232.1 Nine (*omwenda*) is the number the heroine uses for her self-praise, a pun on *okw-enda,* "love." It is an abiding love, like a mother's for her child, a wife's for her husband. It is also a number specified in ritual sacrifices (Schmidt 1978: 99).

233: Changes in hairstyle once marked transitions in life cycle. Today only the bride's "crested-crane" and shaving the head in mourning are widely practiced.

236: The Prattling-one, *Kalamaijo,* is a walking staff used on celebratory occasions; from *oku-lamaija,* "to act in frenzy." (see *Mugasha*: 5.3).

237: Butterfat was traditionally used to make the skin glisten beautifully.

239: A leather skirt was a sign of prestige, indicating the warer's access to cattle.

POETIC STANZAS

221-223.3: *compound stanza*, 2 + 2 + 2, formed in **aab** by contrast between two couplets composed as "my kings"/ "...grind millet" (a's: 221-222, 223-223.1 lines reversed in second) and a single couplet whose second line concludes "...grind sorcery" (b: 223.2-223.3).

She said, "My kings!"
She said, "I ground millet
Women grind millet,
My kings
But I sit at the rocky outcrop,
I grind sorcery!"
She said, "They 'do' themselves with herbs.
225 But today I 'did' myself with the Destroyer!

Hear! Spear of warriors,
Hear! That kills on open ground, 227
He rolls them in blackened grass."

She said, "My child, break open the provisions,"
She said, "And the coffee berries scatter."
230 She said, "Scatter, scatter!"
She said, "Scatter.
From inside me I am driven to revenge."

She said, " *My husband died as one,*
But he'll make nine go along.

Shave a line around my head.
I'll be a young woman."
She said, "No, Mother, you've matured.
235 Let me cut a full circle.
Take your walking staff the *Prattling one* ."

She said, "Rub butterfat on like water,"
She said, "Rub butterfat on like water,"
She said, "Enough to make your leather skirt cling."
240 She said, "We go to Ihangiro to take revenge."

Ahi, "Bakama bange!"
Ahi, "Nkas' obulo -
Abakazi bas' obulo,
Bakama bange -
Ntula aha lwazi,
Ns' amalogo!"
Ahi, "Bekola omubazi.
225 Kilo ekya mbwenu nayekola Omwabya!

Hulila! Ichumu ly' emanzi,
Hulila! Lwitila omu mbuga,
Nazilinga omu miyonga elikwilagula."

Ahi, "Mwaana wange entanda yata,"
Ahi, "N' emwani onage."
230 Ahi, "Naganaga"
Ahi, "Naga.
Enda yangila okwehoola."

Ati, "*Omushaija wange yafa ali omoi,*
Kyonka aligitwalanis' omwenda.

Ontege ekishule.
Mbe mwisiki."
Ahi, "Cheke maawe wakayukile.
235 Oleke nkuteme enkogoto.
Okwate oluhimbo lwawe Kalamaijo."

Ati, "Ogesige kiizi,"
Ati, "Ogesige kiizi,"
Ati, "Empu zikukwate."
240 Ati, "Tugende Ihangilo kwehoola."

221-225: *stanza* in **abab** formed by adding another pair of lines to the previous figure (221-223.3), thus contrasting lines composed as "they"[women] + verb + 'usual' direct object (a's: 223, 224) with lines composed as "I" + verb + 'unusual' direct object (b's: 223.3, 225).

226-227.1: *stanza* in **aab** formed by contrast between lines that begin with the imperative "Hear!" (a's: 226, 227) and a single line that does not (b: 227.1).

228-231.1: *compound stanza*, 2 + 2 + 1, formed in **aab** by couplets with locutives and with commanding verbs (subjunctive or imperative) that stand alone or markedly follow their direct objects (a's: 228 -229, 230-231) contrasted with a single line that has a verb in the indicative mood and an umarked word order of subject, verb, object (b: 231.1).

233-236: *compound stanza*, 2 + 2 + 1, formed in **aab** by couplets composed semantically as hair-style / age group (a's: 233-233.1, 234-235 with the order reversed in the latter) contrasted with a single line that completes a style of self presentation.

237-240: *stanza* in **aaba** formed by contrast between lines with an initial verb (a's: 237, 238, 240) and a line with a final verb (b: 239).

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 241-243.1:
She promises vengeance in a poetic boast of self-praise.

Lines 244-248.1:
She departs and pauses her journey to honor the hero's corpse.

Lines 249-268:
In enemy territory, she meets a series of men who express desire for her. She asks each to identify himself and then rejects him on the putative basis of a totemic incompatibility his self-praise reveals.

NOTES

251 ff.: The women's courtly artifice proceeds by strategic use of female surfaces. Their canny speech manipulates symbolic forms with equal cunning to identify the enemy and penetrate his home. Self-praise (*ebyebugo*) - which began the epic, brought together the heroine and her mate, and foretold his death - again becomes a narrative focus, here, a tool of revelation. Suitors increase their stature by praising animals they have killed in the hunt. But the women perform symbolic sleight-of-hand by interpreting the animals as though they had the totemic significance that regulates and can prevent a marriage. Primary, marriage-regulating totems (*miziro* - "prohibitions") occasionally are mentioned in self-praise, and secondary totems (*mulumuna* - "clan brothers") appear regularly. But killing a woman's clan's totem of either kind would never lead to a prohibition, as, say, sharing the same primary totem could.

253: Pulverizer comes from *okusa*, "to grind" as a stone grinds millet; as an antelope's pounding hooves grind savannah earth to dust.

She said, " *He died as one."*
She said, " *The man will take along nine."*

[Interruption–bard adjusts calabash resonator]

She said, " *He died as one.*
In Ihangiro may he make nine go along."

When I came to Lugongo,
245 The place they killed my man,
I broke off a twig.
I cast it on him.
I said, "My husband, I leave you buried.

Although you died as one,
In Ihangiro I'll make nine go with you."

I straight away took the Lugongo road,
250 I met a man there guarding cattle.
He said, "Woman, I–Wealth-of-the-people–
have married you."
"Before that, begin: recite me your self-praise."
Eeyoo
He said, " *I killed an antelope, Pulverizer of the wilderness."*
She said, "Stop right there. We are prohibited."

255 I took the Kyandai road.
I meet a man guarding cattle.
"Woman, I would marry you."
"Before that, begin: recite me your self-praise."

POETIC STANZAS

244-247.1: *compound stanza*, 2 + 2 + 1, formed in **aab** by couplets of narration that cohere as lines of adverbial clauses in the past perfect and as verb initial lines in the near past, respectively (a's: 244-245, 246-247) and one line of quoted speech (b: 247.1).

228-248.1: *verse passage* in abcbdb formed by contrast between paired lines of Nyakandalo's praise (b's: 232-232.1, 241-243.1, 248-248.1) and stanzas or compound stanzas that further the narrative (a: 228-231.1; c: 233-236, 237-240; d: 244-247.1).

Ahi, "*Yafa ali omoi.*"
Ati, "*Omushaija alitwalana n' omwenda*."

[Interruption–bard adjusts calabash resonator]

Ahi, "*Yafa ali omoi.*
Ihangilo agitwalanise omwenda."

Kanagobile omu Lugongo,
245 Mbali omushaija bamwitiile,
Nahenda ekiti.
Nasiga nakimujugunyaho.
Nti, "Mushaija wange nasiga naziika.

Kyonka wafa oli omoi,
Ihangilo ngitwalanis' omwendai."

Nakwata gumo omu Lugongo.
250 Nshangaho omushaija azemeile
Ahi, "Iwe mukazi nakushwela *Byabantu*."

"Ekya mbele obanze onyebugile."
Eeyoo
Ahi, *"Nkaita akasa Nyamus' eilungu*."
Ahi, "Lekelela aho naiwe twazilana."

255 Nakwata omuhanda Kyandai.
Nshanga omushaija azemeile.
"Iwe mukazi nakushwela."
"Ekya mbele obanze onyebugile."

"I killed a buffalo, Great curved horn, the Hanging-noose."
260 She said, "Stop right there. We are prohibited."

I took the road.
I go. I sight the setting sun.
When I arrived in Nshamba village of Igabilo,
I meet a man the reguarding cattle.
265 "Woman, I'*Wealth-of-the-people*' have married you."
She said, "Before that, begin: recite me your self-praise."
"I killed an elephant, Elder of the wilderness."
I said, "Stop right there. We are prohibited."

I sighted the direction of Kabale.
The Kabale's in Ihangiro kingdom are many.
270 *There is Kabale of Mwamaali,*
The Fearless Hunter of Migongo.
It's not a belt that they can tie around the waist.

By then the cattle were all returning.
I meet a man.
275 His cloak was barkcloth.
"Woman, I '*Wealth-of-the-people' have married you."*
"Before that, begin: recite me your self-praise."

[false start]
He said, " Yesterday at Lugongo,
280 *I killed a man with fair skin.*
He had sideburns and he had a beard.
His name is Kachwenyanja.
Hail! Spear of warriors.
I killed him on white earth.

"Nkaita embogo Kihembe Nyakatanzi."
260 Ati, "Olekelel' aho twazilana."

Nakwata omuhanda.
Ngya ndalamila obugwa izooba.
Kanogobile Nshamba ya Igabilo,
Nshangaho omushaija azemeile.
265 "Iwe mukazi Nakushwela *Byabantu*"
Ati, "Ekya mbele banza onyebugile."

"Nkaita enjoju Mukulu w' eilungu."
Nti, "Olekelel' aho twazilana."

Nalalamila obugya Kabale.
Kabale Ihangilo ni nyingi.
270 Aliyo Kabale ka Mwamaali,
Omutaitiina wa Migongo.
Tiguba mpuuta bakugwekomile enda.

Aho ente zataha bwoli.
Mbuganganwa omushaija iyobobo.
275 Akaba ashumikile olubugu.
"Iwe mukazi nakushwela *Byabantu*."
"Ekya mbele obanze onyebugile."

[Neigolo omu Lugongo ikwataine]
Ahi, *"Nyeigolo omu Lugongo,*
280 *Naita omushaja nayela,*
Ain' amatalila ainamu empembwe.
Eibala ni Kachwenyanja. 282
Habuka! Ichumu ly' emanzi.
Namwitila omu bilikwela.

Plot Outline

Lines 269-287:
Finally, she meets and is proposed to by a poorly dressed man whose praise reveals him to be the killer of Kachwenyanja; she agrees to marry him.

Notes

270: Mwamali is said to have been a man who killed many, then committed suicide and became a possessing spirit.

272: "It's not a belt" is metaphorical praise of the road travelled; it may look like a belt stretching off into the distance, but to walk it is not so easy.

282.1-284: The final appearance of this section of Kachwenyanja's self-praise underlines once again the importance of the poetic form to the plot. Similar words first declared the hero's identity to the heroine, winning her love and her hand in marriage. Their reversal in the depiction (181-182) of the hero's death and dishonor calls the heroine to act (211-211.1, 214 -415). She soon quotes the words, adding the virtues of his warrior identity to her own (226-227). As praise, the lines include the imperative "Hear!" (*Hulila!*), which indexes the generic addressee of such speech - the king or other person of high standing. Warriors had license to command attention and to promise deeds of valor that would gain royal reward. When Nyakandaalo quotes the words she seems to address them to the spirit of the dead hero, signifying that her relationship to him has become like that of a warrior to a king: she will perform fell deeds on his behalf. This analogy is confirmed in her brief address to his corpse, in which she makes the promise that becomes her own self-praise (247.1-248.1). Her boast, unlike the hero's, is not reversed. It completes the logic of its genre, being voiced both before and after its achievement. When the little man appropriates the hero's praise (282.1), he changes the imperative from "Hear!" to "Hail!" (*Habuka!*), a word characteristically addressed to a king, but by his retinue, deferentially, to welcome him as he entered and took a position of preeminence. The substitution articulates the little man's commoner, clan-based, ethical knowledge. He evokes the regal identity of the fallen warrior, adding it to his own social persona with the intonation of a lowborn clansman who has gladly slain his social superior.

Poetic Stanzas

249-283.1: *verse passage* in **aa**a**b** formed by three repeated passages (a's: 249-254, 255-260, 261-267) and a single passage that shares some line types (268, 274, 276, 277) but furthers the narrative (b: 268-283.1).

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 288-297:
The couple lives as newly wed lovers for five days, after which the heroine thinks on revenge.

Lines 298-303:
The heroine tests the sharpness of her knife and awaits his drunken return from carousing.

NOTES

287: Truly possessed, as a spirit does a medium, as a lover does a lover.

300: The the soft pith of a banana plant stalk can be used as a washcloth.

304: She washed his feet, a a full extension of womanly care.

POETIC STANZAS

304 -309: two *stanzas* in **aab** (304 -306.1, 307-309) each beginning with a double verb formula; the first is formed in **aa**a**b** by contrast between lines with first person initial verbs (a's:304, 305, 306) and a line with a third person initial verb (b: 306.1); the second is formed in aab by contrast between first person, verb initial lines of narration (a's: 307, 308) and a line of praise (b: 309).

I rolled him in blackened grass."

"Hear! Spear of warriors.
285 You, man, it's you."

He said, " *I killed and took from him a trophy."*
She said, "Now you've married me and you've truly
possessed me too."

He obliged and married me.
He secluded me two days
290 And two make four.
On the fifth the divorcee emerged.
He said, "I –Wealth-of-the-people–have married you."

When he saw I had emerged . . .
In Ihangiro you know how they drink . . .

295 I said, "My husband . . ."
"You, young girl . . ."
"My husband . . ."
She said (within), "His memory is becoming lost to me.
This day I want revenge."
She said (within), "I want revenge."

We went out among the weeds (to cultivate).
I took my knife.
I sharpened it.
I tried it.
The banana tree fell with a single blow.
300 From the stump I removed the pith.

He'd gone for beer.
And he came home having drunk it.
He was a cattle herder.

I obliged; I washed his feet.
305 I served out food; we ate.
I rubbed him with oil.
He lay completely down

Namuzilinga omu miyonga elikwilagula."

"Hulila! Ichumu ly' emanzi.
285 Iwe mushaija iwe."

Ahi, *"Namwita namwihyaho embembe."*
Ahi, "Mbwenu wanshwela wambandashana."

Yakunda yanshwelakwo.
Akanyalika ebilo bibili
290 Bibili binai.
Ekya katanu enyailiya yayaluka.
Ahi, "Nakushwela *Byabantu*."

Kayaboine nayaluka...
Ihangilo nomanya okwo banywa...

295 Nti, "Mushaija wange -"
"Iwe mwisiki -
"Mushaija wange -"
Ahi, "Yalenga kunyeba.
Kil' eki nagonza kwehoola"
Ahi, "Nagonza kwehoola."

Twagenda omu mwata.
Nakwata n' omuhyo gwange
Nahyola
Nalenga
Engemu yakumba.
300 Omugogo nagukunula.

Akaba agenzile omu malwa.
Yaija aganyoile.
Akaba ali mutunzi w' ente.

Nakunda nanabisa amagulu.
305 Nafuka twalya.
Namutaho amajuta.
Yanyaama bwoli.

I lay down, I followed him.
I revealed to him *the grasshopper*
That has waves like a lake .

310 When languor carried him away,
And he'd been ushered off by snoring,
I raised him up.
The voice box I slashed.

When dawn arose,
I said to his brothers,
315 "In Ihangiro is this how you drink?
My man went for beer yesterday,
And I slept with the plantain pot.
If he's still gone today, come look in on me."

While I was there
I was surprised to see my sister-in-law.
Sister-in-law paid me a visit.
320 I said, "Is this how your brother drinks?
They say it'll be two days before he comes."
Sister-in-law said, "I'll be going now."

While I was there
I was surprised by his brother at dusk.
325 "Come look in on me, child."

I made the bed and we lay in it.
I revealed to him *the grasshopper*
That has waves like a lake.

Nanyaama namuhondela.
Namwoleka *ekimooma*
Ekiina amayengo nk' enyanja.

310 Amalemw' agamwihil' aho,
Olwo yashagailw' ekigono,
Namwimukya
Amalaka nakinda.

Olw' obwile bwakeile,
Nagambila abalumuna,
315 "Ihangilo nikwo muganywa?
Owange agenzile omu malwa nyeigolo,
N' enyungu y' ebitoke ndaile nayo.
Kalabula mbwenu mulankyamiliza."

Kanabaile ndiho
Nyechula omulamu.
Omulamu yazinduka.
320 Nti, "Mulumuna nkwaaganywa?
Ngu yasiga bibili kwija."
Omulamu ahi, "Kanyimuke aha nataha."

Kanabaile ndiho.
Nyechula omulumuna bwaigolo.
325 "Boojo olankyamiliza."

Nayala twanyaama.
Nagya namwoleka *ekimooma*
Ekiina amayengo nk' enyanja.

Plot Outline

Lines 304-312.1:
She plies him with her womanly charms, and when he falls asleep, she cuts his throat.

Lines 313-322:
The next day Nyakandaalo chides the dead man's brothers and sister about his absence.

Lines 323-331.1:
A brother comes to her that night, and she dispatches him with the same method.

Notes

308: The *ekimooma* grasshopper is brown at rest, but jumps and flies to reveal its magenta colored wings: this is praise for a depilated vulva and labia minora.

312.1: The slashed voice-box speaks in the exchange of symbolic violence that began with Kachwenyanja's use of an enemy's corpse to sit upon in self-display (162)and elevate himself for individual recognition and reward. The little man answered by cutting the penis from hero's corpse, a symbolic utterance in a clan discourse of reproduction. Nyakandaalo has the last word in this exchange, asserting the power and knowledge that transcends state and clan. Her destruction of the clansman's voice-box (*amalaka* "larynx" from the plural of *eilaka* "voice") symbolically cuts his power to speak, to praise himself, to be remembered, to attain the immortatity conferred by ritualized artistic speech. Destroying the instrument of rememberance asserts the strength of the bard himself. She embodies this virtue in the very next episode by constructing a poetic memorial for her slain lover with the nameless corpses she has taken. Gruesome acts build a violent, ethically meaningful exchange, a thematic sequence superimposed upon the epic's larger design.

316: Collecting pots of plantains cooked but uneaten would be the act of a knowing, very dutiful, and loving wife.

317: On would usually look in on a friend to maintain friendship or to help during ill health, but here there is ambiguous intent.

324: A woman has a joking relationship with her husband's brother, and sex between them, while not prescribed, is not proscribed as incest (as it is with a husband's father).

Poetic Stanzas

307-353: *verse passage* in **aab** formed by repetition and variation in passages in which only men are killed (a's: 307-325, 326-343) and a final passage in which both men and a woman die (b: 344-353).

PLOT OUTLINE

Lines 332-343:
The next day Nyakandaalo chides the other brothers, who proffer excuses on the husband's behalf.

Lines 344-353:
In the evening, the two brothers visit, along with the sister-in-law; the heroine and her maidservant kill the brothers and then fall upon the sister-in-law and kill her also.

When languor carried him away,
330 And I saw him ushered off by snoring,
I raised him up.
The voice box I slashed.

Again I said to his brothers at dawn,
"Is this how you drink in Ihangiro?
My man went two days ago for beer.
Child, the plantain pots are four.
335 If he's still gone today, come look in on us,
Or leave us alone–we'll go back.
We are two women here."

He said, "Don't be a bit concerned.
In Ihangiro we have cow byres on Buligi island.
340 He's ruled by desire for his divorcee.
He's sure to be at Buligi of Mwoogo.

If he doesn't bring you a cow that's calfed,
He won't fail to bring you one for slaughter."
"If he's still gone today, come look in on me."

They obliged and both came.
345 On that day,
Again my sister-in-law paid a visit.

When the brothers had come,
One lay with I-laugh-knowingly,
The other lay with Kandaalo.
Both revealed to them the *grasshopper* .

When there was languor,
350 Both men were ushered off by snoring.
They raised them up.
Voice boxes they slashed.

In the front room they seized the sister-in-law,
And slashed her voice box as well.

Amalemw' agamwihil' aho,
330 Agonasiga yashagalwa ekigono,
Namwimukya.
Amalaka nakinda.

Nshuba ngambila abalumuna bukeile,
"Nikwo muganywa Ihangilo?
Owange akagenda ijo omu malwa.
Bojo, enyungu z' ebitoke zaba inai.
335 Kalabula mbwenu mulatukyamiliza,
Angili mutuleke -- twataha.
Tulimu abakazi babili."

Ahi, "Nangu otahangaalwa.
Ihangilo tugila ebilalo Buligi.
340 Atwetwe amailu g' enyailiya.
Alaba ali Buligi bwa Mwoogo.

Kalaba atakuleteileyo nzaile,
Angili takulemelweyo kimasha."
"Kalabula mbwenu munkyamilize."

Bakunda baija bombili.
345 Kil' ekyo,
Yashuba omulamukazi yazinduka.

Olwo bamazile kwija,
Ogu yanyaama na *Nshekel' okumanya*,
Ogu lyanyaama na Kandalo.
Boona baboleka *ekimooma*.

Amalemw' agabail' aho,
350 Abashaija boona bashagalwa ekigono.
Bamwihyaho.
Amalaka bakinda.

Bakwata omu mulyango omulamukazi,
Na wenene amalaka bakinda.

Plot Outline

Lines 354-385.1:
Nyakandaalo and her maidservant retrueve the hero's belongings from the house and return to the place of the hero's death; the heroine's poetic speech there combines her own self-praise with a lament for the dead hero.

Notes

360ff.: The epic's concluding commentary is framed as Nyakandaalo's address to the corpse of the royal warrior. It is her victorious self-praise (*eby'ebugo*) spoken before her avenged lover, like one in which a victorious warrior might have asserted his identity before a king. Her soliloquy recounts her heroic accomplishments as a warrior might (360-370.1) and then adds lines of women's traditional elegaic praise (371-379). Her poetry resolves oppositions introduced at several junctures in the narrative. The opposition between clan domesticity and courtly manner, injected in terms of beer and surrounding wifely strategies and locally resolved by a non-clan union, is overcome by the heroine's speech as an embodyment of both courtly warrior-courtesan, whose brave deeds honor the king-like hero, and loving wife, whose intimate praise celebrates his beauty. The dramatic opposition between love and war, locally resolved by the warrior's farewell, is finally resolved by their combination in the courtesan's strategem-making war by making love-and in the careful, poetic equation of the morsels of their short-lived love with the generous servings of her revenge. Finally, the opposition between life and death in battle, between honor and dishonor, locally resolved by the death and dishonor wreaked upon the royal warrior, is transformed by her poetic speech to death with honor, combining enemy corpses heaped in tribute to his memory with praise of his physical beauty and loving ways. With these syntheses of opposing themes and male and female voices, the bard achieves the immortalizing power of his craft.

370: "The fifth" victim is called *omu-shankazi*, which is not a Haya word. It is apparantly a combination of *omushaija,* "man," and *nkazi,* a female marker. It refers to the sister-in-law.

Poetic Stanzas

354 -357: *stanza* in **a**a**ba** formed by contrast between lines comprising independent clauses composed as [...] "they got out" + direct object (a's: 354, 355, 357) and a line comprising a relative clause (b: 356).

360-370.1: *stanza* in **ab-**b**ab**abbabab formed by contrast between lines that comprise a numbered sequence (a's: 360, 363, 365, 368, 370) and lines that recall aspects of the heroic couple's romantic love (b's: 364, 366-367, 369, 370.1).

373-376: *stanza* in **abab** formed by contrast between conditional clauses (a's: 373, 375) and figures of praise (b's: 374, 376).

They got Kachwenyanja's bow.
355 They got his leather kilt and his cloak
That he had taken with the trophy.
They went and got his drinking calabash.

When the woman came to Lugongo,
The place that he had killed him,

360 She said, " *The one I killed first*
Was for his courting of me,
Was for how he carried me away from the foot of a mountain."
She said, " *The second man,"*
She said, " *Was for his love and his longing to see my face."*
365 She said, " *The third man,*
Names not yet pronounced:
His calling to me, 'Dear one, ' and my calling to him, ' Yes, Dear one.'"
She said, " *The fourth man,*
The soul of my husband, Kachwenyanja!"
370 She said, " *The fifth,*
The shadow of my husband."

"You women bereaved of men,
Tell me how you mourn."

She said, " *If he is dark complexioned,"*
She said, " *Dark clouds after rain has fallen."*
375 She said, " *If he is light,"*
She said, " *A tan cow with large, white marks,*

Baihyayo obuta bwa Kachwenyanja.
355 Baihyayo olw' engutu n' ebebo
Ebyo yabaile amwakile nshembe.
Bagya baihyayo n' ekilele.

Omukazi kayaizile omu Lugongo,
Mbali kamwitile,

360 Ati, *"Owo naisile mbele --*
Nikwo kunshelela,
Okwo yanyihile omu bikiika by' eibanga."

Ati, *"Omushaija wa kabili,*
Ahi, *"Nizo ngonzi n' olushusho."*
365 Ati, *"Omushaija wa kashatu,*
Ibala 'lyonabaile ntakamwatwile:
Nanyeta, 'Baaba,' nimweta, 'baaba inya.'"

Ati, *"Omushaija wa kanai,*
Mwoyo gw' omushaijawa Kachwenyanja!"
370 Ati, *"Omushankazi wa katanu,*
Kinyumanyumi ky' omushaija wange."

"*Inywe bakazi baita abashaija,*
Mulangambila okwo muchula."

Ahi, *"Waitu kaba nailagula,"*
Ati, *"Mujumbi gw' enjul' egwile."*
375 Ahi, *"Kaba nayela omubili,"*
Ahi, *"Kagaaju k' olusa lwela,*

Poetic Stanza

380-382: *stanza* alternately in **aba** formed by contrasts between lines composed as "I have lost" + noun phrase (a's: 380, 382) and lines composed as "I have been robbed of" + noun phrase (b: 381); in aab formed by contrast between lines composed as verb + substantive relative clause (a's: 380, 381) and a line composed as verb + noun + adjectival relative clause (b: 382).

A white haired plant.
Shelter from the rain,
Shade from the sun.

380 *I have lost what must not be lost.*
I have been robbed of what cannot be spoken.
I have lost my husband who went to war.

You of Nsheshe and Kailongo.
Hear! I come from Ihangiro with revenge.
385 *My husband died as one.*
But in Ihangiro I made nine go with him."

Enkukulu y' amashoke.
Obwigamo bw' enjula,
Obuhungo bw' omushana.

380 *Inye naita ekitaitwa.*
Naibwa ekyo ntatake.
Naita omushaija atabaile.

Inywe aba Nsheshe na Kailongo.
Hulila! Ninduga Ihangilo kwehoola.
385 *Omushaija wange akafa ali omoi.*
Ihangilo nagitwalanisa omwendai."